AGENTIC COMMERCE · BUSINESS MODELS IN THE VALUE CHAIN · ISSUER VIEW

SEPTEMBER 2026 · WORKING DRAFT

Five business models are forming. They differ on who holds the card, who holds the customer's instruction, and who carries the loss. The network-hosted seat we occupy today is one of them, not the whole table.

Card-on-file still holds: in every model someone stores our card for an agent to use. The business question is who stores it, and what reaches us when we approve or decline.

Intent captured	Discovery & cart	Card presented	Approve or decline	Dispute & loss
AI platforms, wallets, networks (intent records)	AI platforms (UCP, ChatGPT Apps), merchant agents	Network agent tokens, wallet tokens, PSP single-use tokens, virtual cards	Issuer. Only stage no one else can take, but everyone shapes what we see	Issuer carries fraud loss on valid tokens; Amex is selling protection on top

	1 · Network-hosted Where we are today	**2 · AI-platform-led** Platform is the store	**3 · Wallet / card-on-file holder** Stored card extended to agents	**4 · Merchant / PSP-led** Walled-garden agents	**5 · Issuer-led / membership** Own the record, sell the trust
Who runs it (Sep 2026)	Mastercard Agent Pay (all US cardholders since Nov-25; Citi and US Bank first). Visa Intelligent Commerce (30+ EU issuers live Jul-26).	Google AI Mode/Gemini checkout via UCP + Google Pay (Walmart, Target, Shopify). ChatGPT Apps (Walmart, Etsy, Instacart) after Instant Checkout was retired Mar-26. Copilot Checkout with PayPal.	Apple Pay, Google Pay, PayPal, Shop Pay (Shop Token), Amazon. Stripe Link's agent wallet issues a single-use virtual card per purchase (Jul-26).	Stripe Agentic Commerce Suite, Adyen, Checkout.com, Nuvei. Merchant agents: Walmart Sparky, Amazon Rufus / Buy for Me. JPMorgan Payments expects merchant-own agents to land first.	Amex Agentic Commerce Experiences kit + agentic purchase protection (Apr-26); Resy, Offers, Travel embedded in AI platforms. Citi: "AI-powered personal shoppers" (Investor Day May-26). Capital One closed-loop optionality.
How it works	Network registers the agent ("Know Your Agent"), mints a per-agent token with caps and merchant types, enforces them at the network, and passes agent ID plus an intent reference in the transaction.	Platform runs discovery and cart, then pays through its own wallet or a PSP token. Platform can charge the merchant (OpenAI took 4% on Instant Checkout).	The wallet already holds the card; it lends it to agents under its own consent screen, or layers a virtual card on top so the agent never sees ours.	Merchant's own agent buys inside its own storefront; PSP presents a shared or single-use token. Amazon blocks outside agents and is litigating (Perplexity).	Issuer registers agents, provisions its own credentials into agent surfaces, keeps the consent record, embeds benefits in the agent, and sells the fact that it answers the phone.
Where our card sits	Network token vault, one token per agent. Same plumbing as mobile wallet tokens.	In the platform's wallet: card-on-file with Google Wallet, PayPal, Link. We are one saved card among several.	Wallet vault, or one layer beneath a virtual card. Classic card-on-file, now with an agent in front.	Merchant or PSP vault. The oldest card-on-file pattern there is.	Our vault. We provision directly to the surfaces the customer's agent runs on.
Who holds the instruction	Network (Mastercard "Verifiable Intent" record). Cardholder enrolls through our app, so we front the consent moment.	Platform (AP2 signed customer instruction, now FIDO-governed). We are not party to it.	Wallet. Consent UX and limits are the wallet's product, not ours.	Merchant. No cross-merchant record exists.	Us. Cart context and intent are ours to keep and to use in disputes.
What we see at decision	Agent ID, scope, intent reference, standard token cryptogram. Best signal set of the five, but it arrives on the network's schedule and schema.	A tokenized card-not-present transaction from the wallet. Agent indicator only if the wallet chooses to pass it.	Tokenized CNP. If a virtual card is layered on top we see only the funding leg: no merchant, no cart.	Standard CNP card-on-file, possibly with an e-commerce indicator. Least context of the five.	Everything: cart, intent, agent, customer. The only model where the decision sees the whole picture.
Issuer economics	Interchange intact. Network adds token/service fees and becomes the data intermediary. Liability follows tokenized rules: we carry fraud loss when the token is valid.	Interchange intact but CNP. Platform takes the merchant fee and owns the relationship. Risk: we become an invisible funding line.	Interchange, but the funding-card pattern turns us into a balance source with no merchant data and a weaker dispute case.	Interchange. Dispute burden rises: "was the agent's action the customer's?" with no evidence on our side.	Interchange plus protection revenue, fee-product differentiation and a retained relationship. Cost: registry, records, and a service promise we must keep.
Our build / control	Build low. Control medium: we own enrollment and the decision rule; the network owns the registry, scope enforcement and the record.	Build low (push-provision into the wallet). Control low: wallet rules, not ours, govern the agent.	Build none. Control low-medium: wallet controls apply; we can only set card-level limits.	Build none. Control lowest. This is the default if we do nothing.	Build high. Control high. The real business decision is whether this is worth building or renting.

WHERE THE MONEY AND THE RISK MOVE

- Interchange survives in all five. What moves is the relationship, the evidence we hold at dispute time, and whether a fee layer (platform, network, PSP) sits above or below us.
- Loss rules have not moved: on a valid token the issuer carries fraud. So in models 1 to 4 we carry the loss while holding progressively less evidence.
- Rule of thumb: whoever holds the instruction holds the evidence; whoever holds the card holds the relationship. By default today we hold neither.

PRACTICAL STANCE: THREE MOVES, ONE DECISION

NOW · 0–6 MO

Consume

Take Agent Pay and Visa signals into the approve-or-decline rule. Write the agent-initiated dispute policy. Count agent-indicated volume. Table stakes, not a strategy.

NEXT · 6–12 MO

Be present

Push-provision our cards into the three or four surfaces that will carry most agent spend (Google Wallet, PayPal/Copilot, ChatGPT Apps, Shop Pay). Negotiate agent-indicator pass-through with each.

DECIDE · BY 12 MO

Own or rent the record

Either build issuer-side agent registration and our own consent record (the Amex path), or accept renting it from the network and price the data dependency explicitly.

DECISIONS THIS SHOULD FORCE

- Which three surfaces will carry most of our cardholders' agent spend in 2027, and is our card the one saved there?
- Do we hold the instruction record or rent it from the network, and what does renting cost us at dispute time?
- What is our decision rule for an agent-initiated transaction with, and without, an intent reference?
- Where is the revenue beyond interchange: protection, membership benefits inside agents, or an issuer agent of our own?

Working draft for discussion. Positions from public statements by Mastercard, Visa, Stripe/OpenAI, Google, American Express, JPMorgan Payments and trade press as of September 2026; this market moves monthly. Brass marks our decisions; teal marks machine or agent actions.